

CORE FORMULA

Ask -> listen -> follow-up or reflect -> optional brief share -> return. -> Question + support response + small self-disclosure + return question. -> "I have a version of that too, but I want to hear yours first." -> "That reminds me of something, but before I hijack it — what happened next?"

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Ask one real follow-up or reflect before sharing your related story.

BEST FOR

- Keeping conversation centred on the other person when they are sharing something.
- Responding to stories, good news, stress, uncertainty, achievements or frustrations.
- Dating, networking, friendships, workplace rapport and first conversations.
- Preventing accidental self-focus when you are excited to relate.
- Building trust with quieter, guarded or thoughtful people.
- Making your self-disclosure feel like connection rather than competition.

PHRASE BANK

Stop the boomerang · Catch-yourself one-liners

- "Before I make this about me — what happened next?"
- "I have a related story, but yours is the one I want to hear first."
- "I nearly jumped in there — go on."
- "I want to stay with your version for a second."
- "Let me not hijack that. What was that like?"
- "I asked because I actually want the answer."

Support before shifting · Reflect before you relate

- "That sounds like the main part of the story."
- "So the surprising part wasn't the thing everyone asks about."
- "That sounds more complicated than the short version."
- "I can see why that stuck with you."
- "What did you make of it at the time?"
- "What was the part people would miss from the outside?"

Bridge to self without hijacking · Share briefly, then return

- "I've had a smaller version of that, but yours sounds more intense."
- "That reminds me of something — but I'll keep it short."
- "I relate to the uncertainty part. Mine was different, but I get the feeling."
- "I've a version of this too — not to compete, just because I recognise the pattern."
- "I'll give the two-sentence version, then I want to hear what happened next."
- "My version was less dramatic, but the feeling was similar."

Return to them · Hand the floor back

- "Anyway, back to yours — what happened after that?"
- "That is my version, but what did you do next?"
- "How did it land for you?"
- "Was that the part that bothered you most?"
- "Where did that leave things?"

- "What was the best part of it for you?"

Good news · Help them savour the win

- "That is a proper win. What was the best moment?"
- "Nice — when did you realise it had gone well?"
- "What part are you most pleased with?"
- "Who was the first person you told?"
- "What made that feel satisfying?"
- "What did you do to celebrate?"

Stress / frustration · Stay with the hard part

- "That sounds draining. What was the hardest part?"
- "I can see why that would get under your skin."
- "Was it the situation itself, or how people handled it?"
- "What did you need in that moment?"
- "What are you most annoyed people didn't understand?"
- "That sounds hard to explain unless you were there."

Professional / networking · Work and expertise

- "What led you into that area?"
- "What has been the most interesting part of that work?"
- "What surprised you about that role?"
- "What kind of problems do you enjoy solving?"
- "What do people usually misunderstand about your work?"
- "What are you trying to build toward next?"

Digital / text · One-line messages

- "Wait — I want the actual story. What happened?"
- "Before I turn this into my own rant: what did you do?"
- "That sounds like a lot. What was the hardest bit?"
- "I have a similar story, but yours first."
- "What's the short version and the honest version?"
- "That deserves more than 'nice' — what was the best part?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Uses the technique mechanically or too often.

Better: Uses the smallest useful version and then listens.

Best: Uses it only when the cue is present, keeps the wording natural, and adjusts to the response.

2. Weak: Talks about the technique instead of doing it.

Better: Performs one clear behavioural move.

Best: Makes the move feel like ordinary skilled conversation.

DECISION TREE

If They are sharing a story, a win, or a frustration — a cue this move is built for.

Use the minimum viable move: one real follow-up or reflection before anything of your own.

"What was the best part for you?"

If There is no real cue — they want information, not conversation.

Answer plainly, or pick a neighbouring technique; do not force restraint.

"Here's the short answer — tell me if you want the detail."

If The follow-up opened them up.

Stay with their thread once more before you share anything.

"So that was the part that stuck. What happened next?"

If You feel the urge to bridge to your own story.

Give the two-sentence version, then return the floor.

"I have a version of that too — but yours first, what did you do?"

If You have shifted too far onto yourself.

Name it and hand the spotlight back.

"I just made that about me — sorry, go on."

If You have already used the move once.

Don't repeat it mechanically; move to summary, action, or ordinary contribution.

"So where did that leave things?"

SCENARIOS

Social conversation

Use the smallest natural version so they feel heard without feeling analysed. — "What was the best part for you?"

Professional discussion

Keep it concise and tie the move to the task, decision or concern. — "What led you to that call?"

Conflict or objection

Add validation and slow down; do not weaponise the restraint. — "Before I give my side — what mattered most to you here?"

Digital message

Use one sentence. Avoid long explanations or stacked questions. — "Wait — I want the actual story. What happened?"

Shy or guarded person

Make the move lighter, more tentative and lower pressure. — "No rush, but I'd like the real version, not the polite one."

High-status or busy person

Keep the wording brief, grounded and useful. — "What surprised you most about that?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The other person explicitly asks about your experience or opinion.
- A balanced back-and-forth is already established and your story genuinely adds value.
- You over-correct and ask so many questions that it becomes an interview.
- The person wants direct information, not emotional support or conversation.
- Your related story is genuinely the most useful way to answer, teach, warn or empathise.
- You are using restraint to hide, perform mystery, or avoid real reciprocity.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the boomerang

Through the day, notice three times someone asks a question and then answers it themselves or swings straight to their own story. Just observe the pattern in others.

Day 2 — Catch your own urge

In your own conversations, catch the launchpad urge — the moment you ask something mainly to set up your own story. Note when it happens, without changing anything yet.

Day 3 — Write the minimum move

Take three ordinary things someone might say ('I got a new job', 'The trip was exhausting') and write one genuine follow-up or reflection for each, before any story of your own.

Day 4 — Say them naturally

Read yesterday's lines aloud once. Cut anything that sounds clever, therapeutic, corporate or performative until each sounds like ordinary you.

Day 5 — Support before shifting, live

In one real conversation, ask a question and give a full support response — a follow-up or reflection — before adding anything about yourself.

Day 6 — Bridge and return

Once today, share a short related story, then deliberately hand the thread back with a return question. Keep your version

shorter than theirs.

Day 7 — Recover on purpose

When you notice you've boomeranged — you will — practise naming it and returning the floor: 'I just made that about me, go on.' Notice how quickly it repairs the moment.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I ask because I wanted their answer, or because I wanted to talk?
- Did I give a real support response before sharing anything of my own?
- Was my own story shorter than their thread?
- Did I return the floor, or did the topic quietly become about me?
- Did I adjust if they went quiet or started giving short answers?
- If this missed, which neighbouring technique would have fitted better?